METHODISM: 101

SESSION 1: HISTORY & FOUNDATIONS

GRACE COMMUNITY CHURCH

Where did we come from? Methodism: 101 is part of our **Faith: 101** Bible study series. Tonight is our family history: where the word "Methodist" came from, why there are several Methodist churches, and what Methodists believe. Grace Community Church is part of the **Christian Methodist Episcopal (CME) Church**. Fill in the blanks as we go.
The lettered questions match the slides; jot your thoughts as we talk.

> **QUESTION A** What's one thing you were taught about the church you grew up in — or one thing you've always wondered about Methodists?

PART 1 · A MOVEMENT, NOT A NEW CHURCH

THE HOLY CLUB AT OXFORD (1729)

1. In 1729, a small group of students met at _____ University. It was started by _____, and his brother John soon became its leader.

2. They prayed, studied Scripture, took Communion, fasted, visited prisoners and helped the poor. Other students mocked them as "Methodists" because they were so _____.

3. Methodism began as a _____ inside the _____, not as a new church.

> **QUESTION B** Wesley's friends were mocked for being so "methodical." If someone watched your week, what spiritual habits would they notice?
> *"Train yourself to be godly."* **1 Timothy 4:7**

ALDERSGATE (MAY 24, 1738)

4. Listening to Luther's preface to Romans, John Wesley wrote, "I felt my heart _____. I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone, for salvation."

> **QUESTION C** Have you had an "Aldersgate moment," when your heart was "strangely warmed"? Or has your faith warmed slowly over time?
> *"Were not our hearts burning within us while he talked with us on the road and opened the Scriptures to us?"* **Luke 24:32**

FIELD PREACHING (1739)

5. When many pulpits closed to him, _____ urged Wesley to preach outdoors to coal miners and working people.

6. Wesley wrote that the gospel knows "no religion, but social; no holiness, but _____." Faith grows together, in small groups, and reaches outward to neighbors.

> **QUESTION D** Wesley said there is "no holiness but social holiness." Who helps you grow in faith — and whom are you helping grow?
>
> *"Let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds."* **Hebrews 10:24**

TO AMERICA (1784)

7. At the "Christmas Conference" in _____, the _____ was organized. Black Methodists like the preacher Harry Hosier were part of it from the start.

PART 2 · FOUR FAMILIES, ONE STORY

Methodism grew fast among Black and white Americans. But racism — segregated seating, denied ordination and the church's compromise with slavery — divided the family.

8. In 1844 the Methodist Episcopal Church split North and South over _____.

AFRICAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL (AME) · 1816

At St. George's Church, Black worshipers were pulled up off their knees while praying. Absalom Jones, Richard Allen and others walked out. Allen's Bethel church (1794) won control of its own building in court in 1816.

9. The AME Church was founded in _____ in 1816. Its first bishop was _____.

> **QUESTION E** Richard Allen and Absalom Jones were pulled up off their knees while praying. What does that moment say about how the church has treated people — and how should it treat them?
>
> *"There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free… for you are all one in Christ Jesus."* **Galatians 3:28**

AFRICAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL ZION (AME ZION) · 1821

Led by James Varick, Black members of New York's John Street Church left segregated Communion and denial of ordination behind. Harriet Tubman, Frederick Douglass and Sojourner Truth were connected to this church, an early ordainer of women.

10. AME Zion is known as _____.

CHRISTIAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL (CME) · 1870 · OUR FAMILY

After emancipation, Black members of the Methodist Episcopal Church, South asked for their own church, governed by themselves. Their first bishops were William H. Miles and Richard H. Vanderhorst. The CME built Lane, Miles, Paine and Texas colleges.

11. The CME Church was organized in _____ in _____.

12. The "C" first stood for _____. Since 1956 it has stood for _____.

THE UNITED METHODIST CHURCH (UMC) · 1968

13. In 1939, every Black congregation in The Methodist Church was placed in a segregated, nationwide _____. It ended with the merger that formed the UMC in _____.

QUESTION F Allen walked out and built something new. Others stayed and worked for change from inside. When is leaving the right response, and when is staying?

QUESTION G Grace is part of the CME Church, founded by formerly enslaved people who wanted to govern their own church. What does it mean to you to belong to this story?

"You also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house." **1 Peter 2:5**

PART 3 · WHAT METHODISTS BELIEVE

14. Wesley taught that grace is God at work through our whole life. The three kinds of grace:

GRACE	WHAT IT MEANS	SCRIPTURE (NIV)
_____ grace that goes before	God's love reaching us before we know God, drawing us to respond.	*"We love because he first loved us."* **1 John 4:19** Also: Jeremiah 31:3 · John 6:44
_____ grace that pardons	Forgiveness and a restored relationship with God, received by faith — a gift.	*"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith."* **Ephesians 2:8–9** Also: Romans 5:1
_____ grace that transforms	The Holy Spirit growing us, over a lifetime, toward perfect love of God and neighbor.	*"If anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come."* **2 Corinthians 5:17** Also: Philippians 2:12–13 · 1 Thessalonians 5:23

QUESTION H Which do you most need right now: grace that finds you (prevenient), grace that forgives you (justifying), or grace that grows you (sanctifying)?

15. Wesley's General Rules (1743), often called the "three simple rules":

1. _____	*"Hate what is evil; cling to what is good."* **Romans 12:9** · 1 Thessalonians 5:15
2. _____	*"Let us do good to all people."* **Galatians 6:9–10** · Micah 6:8
3. _____	Prayer, Scripture, Communion, worship, fasting. *"Remain in me."* **John 15:5** · Jude 1:21

QUESTION I Which of the three simple rules — do no harm, do good, stay in love with God — is hardest for you right now? What would practicing it look like this week?

"He has shown you, O mortal, what is good." **Micah 6:8**

16. The Wesleyan Quadrilateral: four sources for thinking through hard questions. The first is the foundation.

1 _____	**2** _____	**3** _____	**4** _____
2 Timothy 3:16–17	2 Thessalonians 2:15	Isaiah 1:18 · Romans 12:2	Romans 8:16

QUESTION J Try the Quadrilateral: should I forgive someone who hasn't apologized? What do Scripture, tradition, reason and experience each add?

"Lord, how many times shall I forgive…? Up to seven times? Jesus answered, 'I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.'" **Matthew 18:21–22**

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE

The early Methodists didn't just learn about faith; they practiced it, together. Choose one specific action for each rule and bring your story next Wednesday.

DO NO HARM

One habit, word or reaction I'll give up for seven days:

DO GOOD

One person I'll help, by name, before next Wednesday:

STAY IN LOVE WITH GOD

One daily practice (10 minutes of prayer, a psalm a day, a Gospel chapter):

NOTES AND QUESTIONS

BIBLE STUDY EVERY WEDNESDAY · 7:00 PM ET

Zoom ID **880 2297 9559** · Passcode **19061906** · Also live on Facebook

Handouts at gracecommunityphilly.org